



Bespoke success: Payal used a customised equipment that integrated a specialised mechanism into her prosthetic and secured it to her shoulder.

PTI



In 2015, while Payal's parents were working at a brick kiln in Raipur, Chhattisgarh, she was wandering around like any other seven-year-old when tragedy struck. **She came into contact with a live wire and lost all four of her limbs.**

Despite societal taunts about their daughter's future, her parents took care of her in their hometown of Balangir, Odisha. Barsha (**left**), her elder sister, became a major support.

Gradually, Payal developed a liking for painting and would sketch with her mouth. In 2022, for her overall

development, she was taken to Parbati Giri Bal Niketan — a government childcare institute.

"Our District Collector sir took me to the ashram. I used to draw even when I was at home and had participated in one or two competitions. I used to sing as well. At the institute, competitions among the kids were held on a regular basis. There, a teacher named Prachi guided me," recalls Payal.

"Then came a big drawing competition, Surbhi, where I won first prize. I went on to compete at the state level; that's when someone tweeted about me."

Call it the power of social media or pure destiny — Kuldeep Vedwan, Sheetal's coach, noticed Payal.

Vedwan, whom Payal addresses as Guru Ji, contacted the institute, got in touch with the District Collector, and made arrangements to bring Payal, along with Barsha as her caretaker, to the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board Academy in Katra, Jammu and Kashmir.